opposed by Gandhi and the Indian National Congress for long. Frequent communal clashes in the 1940s re-enforced the stance of the Muslim League. The case for Partition was debated at length and dissected from multiple angles in the 1940s but the modus operandi of the final decision was remarkably absent from these discussions. The freedom fighters and British policymakers were likely to have been well aware of the ghastly population exchange of nearly two million people between Greece and Turkey on religious lines in the early 1920s, but in that case a formal exchange was agreed upon *after* a refugee crisis and not before. With the benefit of hindsight, the lack of consideration on the physical movement of people at the policy level appears to have been striking. To a question on the foresight of mass transfer of population at a press conference on 4 June 1947, Mountbatten replied:[14]

> Personally, I don't see it. There are many physical and practical difficulties involved. Some measure of transfer will come about in a natural way. That is to say I have a feeling that people who have just crossed the boundary will transfer themselves. Perhaps Governments will take steps to transfer populations. Once more, this is a matter not so much for the main parties as for the local authorities living in the border areas to decide.

In June 1947, British exit and Partition were imminent within two months but the exact contours of the new boundaries were yet to be finalized. Worse, the decision of the Boundary Commission, chaired by Cyril Radcliffe (1899–1977) during his first and only visit to India, on the bifurcation of Punjab in the west and Bengal in the east was delayed and released two days after the formal transfer of power on August 17. Independent India was thus born prematurely, without definite borders, waiting for its umbilical cord in the wings to be cartographically clipped after two days.

The Western Front

When the Boundary Commission awards were finally announced, officials of newly formed Pakistan condemned it calling it 'disgusting', 'extremely unfair and unjust', 'based on no principles', and found it violating the